DRAFT

Set Up a Cleaner-Air Room for Wildfire Smoke

A cleaner-air room can reduce wildfire-smoke particles while it is safe to remain indoors. Prepare it before smoke arrives, if possible.

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

A smoke shelter is not flame shelter. A cleaner-air room does not protect you from flames, extreme heat, or an approaching wildfire.

An air cleaner reduces particles; it does not supply oxygen, control heat, remove every gas, or make an unsafe building safe..

1. CHOOSE THE ROOM

Choose one room where everyone who needs cleaner air can spend time comfortably.

- ☐ It has a door and as few windows and exterior doors as practical, so it can be closed off.
- ☐ It is large enough for the people and animals who will use it, without blocking exits.
- ☐ It can remain at a safe, comfortable temperature. A closed room can become dangerously hot.
- ☐ It has electricity for an air cleaner and space around the unit for unobstructed airflow.
- ☐ It is away from indoor smoke, cooking fumes, and other particle sources.

Bring needed medicines, water, a phone and charger, and the household's alert information. Never block a required exit.

2. KEEP SMOKE OUT—WITHOUT TRAPPING DANGEROUS HEAT

- Close the room's windows and doors. Limit trips in and out. Close other windows and exterior doors in the home when it is safe to do so.
- For a central heating or cooling system, use **recirculate** mode and close the outdoor-air intake **only if the system's verified manufacturer or HVAC guidance says how**. Use a high-efficiency system filter that the manufacturer says the system can accommodate, and install it in the correct direction.
- If a window air conditioner has an outdoor-air damper, close it. Do not assume every air conditioner recirculates indoor air: portable single-hose units and evaporative coolers can bring in or pull in outdoor air. Follow the equipment manual or advice from a qualified HVAC professional.
- Do not tape over, disconnect, or alter combustion-air openings, exhausts, or other safety ventilation. Never defeat a smoke alarm or carbon-monoxide (CO) alarm.
- If closing the home makes it too hot, go to a cleaner-air center, cooling center, or other safe air-conditioned place identified by local officials. Heat can be immediately dangerous.

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3. USE A PORTABLE AIR CLEANER

Choose a unit that mechanically filters particles and does **not** intentionally produce ozone. Check the label or manufacturer's documentation rather than relying on words such as “air purifier.”

1. Measure the room's floor area. Choose a unit with a **smoke clean-air delivery rate (CADR) at least two-thirds of that area in square feet**, as recommended by EPA for rooms with 8-foot ceilings. A larger or taller room, open doorway, or heavy smoke may require more capacity; use EPA's sizing table or the manufacturer's verified room-size guidance.

2. Place the cleaner in the room where people spend the most time. Keep the air inlet and outlet clear of walls, curtains, furniture, and other obstructions. Follow the required clearance, electrical, and placement instructions in its manual.

3. Close windows and doors and run the unit as continuously as practical, at the highest speed that is tolerable. A lower speed filters less air.

4. Check the filter often during smoke events. Replace it when it is dirty, when the indicator or manual directs, or when airflow drops. Use the type specified by the manufacturer; unplug the unit before service and install the filter in the marked direction.

4. IF A DO-IT-YOURSELF AIR CLEANER IS THE ONLY OPTION

EPA reports that a well-constructed **box-fan-and-filter** air cleaner can temporarily reduce smoke particles, but its performance varies and a tested commercial unit is preferred. Use only a design published by EPA, AirNow, or your public-health authority, and follow that authority's current parts, assembly, and operating directions exactly. Do not invent a fan/filter arrangement or treat it as permanent equipment.

> △ **CAUTION — PREVENT HARM**
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> **Prevent shock and fire:** use a certified box fan made in 2012 or later with a fused plug and a safety mark such as UL or ETL. Inspect the fan, plug, and cord; do not use damaged equipment. Plug it directly into a suitable wall outlet—never an extension cord—and keep it away from water, curtains, clutter, children, and pets. Keep airflow clear. Do not leave it unattended or use it while sleeping.

An awake adult should supervise it. Turn it off and unplug it if it smells hot, makes unusual noise, vibrates, tips, is damaged, or the plug or cord becomes hot. Replace a dirty filter according to the verified design's directions. A DIY unit is not a substitute for leaving excessive heat, heavy smoke that continues indoors, a CO hazard, or a threatened building.

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5. DO NOT ADD PARTICLES OR COMBUSTION GASES

In the cleaner-air room and the rest of the home:

- Do not smoke or vape, burn candles or incense, or use a fireplace or wood stove.
- Avoid frying or broiling food. Use lower-particle cooking methods only when they can be used safely.
- Avoid vacuuming unless the vacuum has a HEPA filter; it can stir particles back into the air.
- Do not use aerosol sprays. Limit activities that stir up dust.
- Never use a generator, charcoal grill, camp stove, gasoline engine, or other fuel-burning device inside a home, garage, basement, shed, or near a door, window, or vent. Never heat the room with a gas oven or range.

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Carbon monoxide cannot be seen or smelled. Keep working CO alarms in the home. Headache, dizziness, weakness, nausea, vomiting, chest pain, or confusion can indicate CO poisoning. Get everyone into fresh air and call 911 immediately; do not re-enter until responders say it is safe.

6. KEEP CHECKING CONDITIONS

- ☐ **Official information:** monitor local emergency alerts and evacuation directions. Check current air quality and smoke forecasts through AirNow or the air-quality agency identified by local officials.
- ☐ **Room conditions:** check temperature, comfort, visible or smelled smoke, air-cleaner airflow, and filter loading. A consumer particle monitor may show trends, but follow its instructions and do not let one reading override symptoms or official directions.
- ☐ **People:** check one another for coughing, wheezing, trouble breathing, chest tightness or pain, palpitations, unusual fatigue, headache, dizziness, confusion, or worsening of a medical condition.
- ☐ **Building safety:** keep exits clear and smoke and CO alarms active. Watch for power loss, electrical problems, fire, or worsening outdoor conditions.

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7. KNOW WHEN TO LEAVE OR GET HELP

Relocate to an official cleaner-air space, cooling center, or another safer building if the room becomes excessively hot; smoke continues to enter; filtration or essential power fails; a smoke or CO alarm sounds; the building becomes unsafe; or anyone cannot remain there safely. Check that the destination and route are open before travel when time allows.

Get medical help for symptoms that are severe, rapidly worsening, or not improving after moving to cleaner air. Call 911 for trouble breathing, chest pain, confusion, fainting, suspected CO poisoning, or another medical emergency. People with heart or lung disease, pregnant people, children, older adults, and others at higher risk should follow their clinician's action plan and seek advice early.

Evacuate immediately when officials direct, fire approaches, flames or embers threaten, or staying could cut off a safe exit. Do not rely on filtration against fire gases or flames.

RELATED HANDOUTS

Use **EVS-003** for your evacuation plan and **EVS-007** for additional wildfire-smoke actions. Current official directions always override a worksheet or handout.

SOURCES

Sources: U.S. EPA, “Create a Clean Room to Protect Indoor Air Quality During a Wildfire,” “Wildfires and Indoor Air Quality,” “Air Cleaners and Air Filters in the Home,” and “Research on DIY Air Cleaners to Reduce Wildfire Smoke Indoors”; AirNow, “Indoor Air Filtration Factsheet”; CDC, “About Carbon Monoxide.” Accessed 2026-09-25.